

Partisanship in Belgian Parliamentary Speech

Evidence from the Chamber of Representatives, 1831–2025

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ABSTRACT

How polarized has Belgian politics been over the long run, and how did partisanship respond to the extensions of the suffrage, to proportional representation and to the split of the parties along linguistic lines? This project measures partisanship in the speeches of the Belgian Chamber of Representatives from its first sitting in 1831 to 2025, with the method that Gentzkow, Shapiro and Taddy (2019) developed for the US Congress and that Simola, Nieminen and Tukiainen (2025) applied to a century of Finnish parliamentary speech. Partisanship is the expected posterior probability that a neutral observer, after hearing one phrase of a member's speech, places on the member's true party. The data are the Belgian Chamber Debates dataset (Graziani 2026): more than two million speeches linked to the speaker's party, district and biography. Belgium allows three extensions of the existing evidence. The series begins under census suffrage, so it spans the whole transition from an elite electorate to mass democracy. The party system grew out of three cleavages—religious, socioeconomic and linguistic—that can be measured as separate splits. And the debates are held in two languages, so partisanship has to be separated from language itself.

RESEARCH DESIGN

Data. The Belgian Chamber Debates dataset covers every plenary sitting from 1831 to 2025, with gaps during the two German occupations. Speeches are segmented from the OCR text of the *Moniteur belge* and the *Annales parlementaires*, and from the Chamber's own reports in recent years, and linked on the date of the sitting to the member's party, district, gender, age, education and ministerial office; each speech records its language, and the roll-call votes of the same sittings are included.

Measure and estimation. As in the two studies replicated, speeches are reduced to stemmed two-word phrases, without procedural phrases, names and the turns of the chair, and counted by speaker and parliamentary year, with the vocabulary thresholds of Gentzkow et al. Phrase-choice probabilities come from a multinomial logit with a lasso penalty on the party effects, estimated through its Poisson approximation (Taddy 2015), with the penalty chosen by BIC and controls for the speaker's gender, the region of the district and the government status of the party. Without penalization the estimate is dominated by finite-sample bias, because most phrases are used only a few times in any year. Confidence intervals come from subsampling, and each series is shown against a placebo in which party labels are reassigned at random, holding party shares fixed. The leave-out estimator, which

Graziani and Vanschoonbeek (2026) use to study the reforms of 1894 and 1900, serves as a robustness check. Because OCR noise tends to blur the differences between parties, its effect on the early decades is measured by adding simulated OCR errors to recent, clean text.

Language. Between 1968 and 1978 the national parties split along linguistic lines, after which each party speaks to one language community: a pooled measure would then detect language rather than partisanship. We therefore build separate vocabularies for French and Dutch, compare only parties that speak the same language, and average the two communities by their share of speech. Before the split, the region control absorbs the differences between Flemish and Walloon members of a party.

Parties. Like Simola et al., we measure partisanship along two-group splits, but in Belgium each split can follow a historical cleavage: the Catholic family against the other parties (religious), the left against the rest (socioeconomic, from 1894, when the socialists entered the Chamber), and government against opposition. Pairwise series for the three traditional families—Catholic, Liberal and Socialist, all in the Chamber since 1894—keep the comparison fixed as new parties enter.

Analyses.

- (1) Long-run series for each split, interpreted through the most partisan phrases of each period and checked against episodes of known conflict: the first school war (1879–1884), the Royal Question of the late 1940s, and the second school war, closed by the School Pact of 1958.
- (2) Partisanship around the institutional changes of the period: plural voting (1893), proportional representation (1899), universal male suffrage (1919), women’s suffrage (1948), the split of the national parties and federalization.
- (3) The linguistic cleavage before the split: whether Flemish and Walloon members of the same national party came to speak differently, with region in place of party as the group.
- (4) Decompositions between and within topics, using the topic labels being added to the dataset, to tell whether parties diverge in what they talk about or in how they talk about it; and between and within members, to separate the renewal of the Chamber from the adaptation of sitting members.
- (5) Comparison with the American and Finnish series on a common scale—the probability of guessing a member’s party after one minute of speech—and with the divisions between parties in roll-call votes.

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